

Daily Content Intel

August 12, 2026

Topic A — Reel

TELEPROMPTER COPY (paste into Instagram)

Okay, if you have an athlete who shot up over the summer and suddenly looks a step slow on the field, there's a study out this week that explains exactly what you're watching.

Researchers tracked 129 elite youth soccer players, U14 through U19, and sorted them by how fast they were growing. Fast group was over 7.2 centimeters a year. Slow group was under 3.5.

The slow growers beat everybody. Better jumps, better sprints, better change of direction, better Nordic hamstring strength. The kids in the middle of a growth spurt tested worse

across the board. That's biology doing its thing.

The part that surprised me was the imbalance data. They measured left to right asymmetry in all three groups and found no meaningful difference, and when they looked at which leg was the weak one, it kept switching sides.

So two things for Monday. If your athlete is growing fast, compare his numbers to his own numbers from 8 weeks ago, and stop comparing him to the kid next to him. And leave his program alone when a 10% side to side gap shows up, because that gap probably flips next month anyway.

Keep him lifting, keep him sprinting, keep him jumping, and let the engine catch up to the frame.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Hook: Your kid grew 4 inches this summer and now he looks slower. Here's what the data says is happening.

Spoken script (word for word):

Okay, if you have an athlete who shot up over the summer and suddenly looks a step slow on the field, there's a study out this week that explains exactly what you're watching.

Researchers tracked 129 elite youth soccer players, U14 through U19, and sorted them by how fast they were growing. Fast group was over 7.2 centimeters a year. Slow group was under 3.5.

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at which leg was the weak one, it kept switching sides.

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On-screen text seeds:

- 0:00 He grew 4 inches. Now he's slow.
- 0:08 129 elite youth players, U14 to U19
- 0:15 Fast growers: over 7.2 cm/year
- 0:25 Slow growers won every physical test
- 0:38 Left vs right imbalance: no real difference
- 0:47 The "weak" leg kept switching sides

- 0:55 Compare him to himself, 8 weeks ago
- 1:05 Let the engine catch up to the frame

Caption (copy-paste ready):

Growth spurt season is here, and half the parents I talk to think their kid got lazy.

New research out of the Journal of Sports Sciences tracked 129 elite youth soccer players, U14 through U19, and split them by how fast they were growing. The fast growers, over 7.2 cm a year, tested worse on jumps, sprints, change of direction, and hamstring strength than the kids whose growth had settled down.

That's a body reorganizing around new levers. It shows up on the field before it shows up anywhere else.

The imbalance piece is the one I want coaches to hear. Growth rate had no meaningful relationship with left to right asymmetry, and the "weak" side kept switching between tests. So a 10% gap in a growing athlete is a snapshot, and rebuilding his whole program around it is usually

wasted work.

What I do instead: keep him strong through the spurt, keep him sprinting at full speed, and score him against his own numbers from 8 weeks ago.

If your athlete is in the middle of one of these and you want eyes on it, booking is at threshold.clientsecure.me.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Dr. Lars Stevenson, PT, DPT

#youthsports #highschoolfootball #lacrosse
#strengthandconditioning
#athletedevelopment #sportsPT
#growthspurt #speedtraining #footballtraining
#northernvirginia

Personalize this

- Which of your current HS football or lacrosse athletes is visibly mid-spurt right now, and what did his jump or sprint numbers do over the last 8 weeks? Naming that arc on camera makes the study land.

- You program HS football strength. What do you actually hold constant through a growth spurt (Nordics, heavy pulls, sprint exposure) versus what you back off, and why?
- Have you ever had a parent or a coach hand you a "he's got an imbalance" screen result on a growing kid? How did you talk them off it, and what did you test instead?

Screenshots:

- title |
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/42572198/>
| "Impact of growth rate on physical performance and inter-limb asymmetry in young elite male soccer players"
- physiology |
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/42572198/>
| "slow growers generally outperformed the other groups in physical tests"
- actionable |
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/42572198/>
| "no significant differences in inter-limb asymmetry were found"

Sources:

- <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/42572198/>
- <https://doi.org/10.1080/02640414.2026.2713900>

Topic B — Reel

TELEPROMPTER COPY (paste into Instagram)

Okay, hot take. The high bar versus low bar argument is eating time your athlete could spend getting stronger.

New study out this week wired up 18 experienced lifters, 9 of them competitive powerlifters, with 14 EMG sensors, and had them squat every way you can squat. High bar and low bar. Wide stance and narrow stance. Heavy triples at 80% and sets of 10 at 50%.

Almost nothing separated the variations. Wide stance drove about 27% more vastus medialis than narrow. Heavy weight drove more vastus lateralis and more semitendinosus, which, yeah, heavy is heavy. Rectus femoris, gastroc, and glute max showed zero difference across every single combination.

The authors' own line is the one I'd put on the wall. Technique and repetition ranges should be selected for comfort of the athlete, as opposed to targeting specific results, because all of it activates the muscles in the legs.

Small study, 18 people, so hold it loosely. But for a high school football or lacrosse athlete, this is easy. Pick the bar position his shoulders tolerate. Pick the stance his hips like. Then go add weight to it for 12 weeks.

The squat is already hitting the whole leg. The argument is worth a couple percent. The bar going up is worth a lot more than that.

Does that make sense?

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Hook: High bar or low bar, wide stance or narrow. New EMG data says your athlete should stop caring.

Spoken script (word for word):

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Almost nothing separated the variations. Wide stance drove about 27% more vastus medialis than narrow. Heavy weight drove more vastus lateralis and more semitendinosus, which, yeah, heavy is heavy. Rectus femoris, gastroc, and glute max showed zero difference across every single combination.

The authors' own line is the one I'd put on the wall. Technique and repetition ranges should be selected for comfort of the athlete, as opposed to targeting specific results, because all of it activates the muscles in the legs.

Small study, 18 people, so hold it loosely. But for a high school football or lacrosse athlete, this is easy. Pick the bar position his shoulders tolerate. Pick the stance his hips like. Then go add weight to it for 12 weeks.

The squat is already hitting the whole leg. The argument is worth a couple percent. The bar going up is worth a lot more than that.

Does that make sense?

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On-screen text seeds:

- 0:00 High bar vs low bar. Stop caring.
- 0:08 18 lifters, 14 EMG sensors, every squat variation
- 0:20 Wide stance: about 27% more VMO
- 0:28 Heavy weight: more vastus lateralis, more semitendinosus
- 0:36 Rectus femoris, gastroc, glute max: no difference at all
- 0:48 "Selected for comfort of the athlete"
- 1:00 Pick what his shoulders and hips tolerate
- 1:10 Then add weight for 12 weeks

Caption (copy-paste ready):

Hot take: the high bar versus low bar argument is eating time your athlete could spend getting stronger.

A study published this week put 18 experienced lifters, 9 of them competitive powerlifters, under 14 EMG sensors and ran them through every squat combination. High bar and low bar, wide and narrow stance, heavy triples at 80% and sets of 10 at 50%.

Wide stance produced about 27% more vastus medialis activation than narrow.

Heavier weight produced more vastus lateralis and semitendinosus. Rectus femoris, gastrocnemius, and gluteus maximus showed no difference across any combination.

The authors put it plainly: technique and repetition ranges should be selected for comfort of the athlete, as opposed to targeting specific results, because all of the variations activate the muscles in the legs.

It's 18 people and it's acute EMG, so hold it loosely. The practical read still holds. Pick

the bar position his shoulders tolerate, pick the stance his hips like, and then spend the next 12 weeks adding weight to that bar.

Strength is the goal. The variation is the packaging.

If you want a second set of eyes on your athlete's lifting before the season, booking is at threshold.clientsecure.me.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Dr. Lars Stevenson, PT, DPT

#squat #highschoolfootball #lacrosse

#strengthandconditioning

#athletedevelopment #sportsPT

#powerlifting #strengthtraining

#footballtraining #northernvirginia

Personalize this

- Which bar position do you actually default to with your HS football athletes, and what shoulder or hip finding makes you switch a kid off it? That call is the whole Reel.
- Do you have an athlete whose squat you changed for comfort or tolerance and whose numbers took off afterward? A

10-second version of that story sells this harder than the EMG data.

- Where does the squat sit inside CROSS for you, and what do you tell a coach who insists low bar is the only "real" squat for football?

Screenshots:

- title | <https://journals.plos.org/plosone/article?id=10.1371/journal.pone.0354893> | "The effects of bar positioning, stance width, repetition, and load on muscle activity during the barbell back squat"
- physiology | <https://journals.plos.org/plosone/article?id=10.1371/journal.pone.0354893> | "The average area under the curve when performing wide stance squats showed a relative increase of 26.6% when compared to narrow stance variations"
- actionable | <https://journals.plos.org/plosone/article?id=10.1371/journal.pone.0354893> | "Technique and repetition ranges should be selected for comfort of the athlete, as opposed to targeting specific results, as all methods activate the muscles in the legs"

Sources:

- <https://journals.plos.org/plosone/article?id=10.1371/journal.pone.0354893>
- <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0354893>

Reference

Runner-up topics

- Sprint Speed Adaptations in Elite Soccer Players: Are Improvements Greater Over Longer Distances? (J Strength Cond Res, Aug 11, PMID 42579440): where speed training actually shows up on the clock.
- Early-season changes in concentric-only, long and short stretch-shortening cycle jump performance in highly trained youth basketball players (Ann Med, Aug 7, PMID 42567709): what preseason does to the spring in an athlete's legs.
- Explaining High-Velocity Movement: Do Isometric or Heavy Strength Measures Show Stronger Associations? (Int J Sports Physiol Perform, Aug 4, PMID 42562362): hot-take fuel on gym testing that predicts nothing on the field.

Sources scanned today

- Newsletter digest
newsletter_digest_2026-08-12.pdf: 1
source processed (Dr. Mercola
promotional email, plastics/supplement ad

copy). Nothing clinically usable, skipped.

- PubMed recent feed (sprint / change of direction / strength and conditioning, athletes, sorted by date): 25 papers from Aug 4-11, 2026 reviewed. Strongest athlete-facing items: growth rate and inter-limb asymmetry in youth soccer (J Sports Sci, Aug 9), BFR and explosive power meta-analysis (JSCR, Aug 7), sprint speed adaptations over longer distances in elite soccer (JSCR, Aug 11), early-season SSC jump changes in youth basketball (Ann Med, Aug 7).
- Frontiers in Physiology (2026): two open-access BFR papers read in full (team-athlete meta-analysis, 8-week collegiate sprinter trial). A "BFR doesn't build explosiveness" hot take was drafted and then REJECTED at the dedup gate: the meta-analysis URL was already cited on 2026-07-09, inside the 90-day window. Swapped to the PLoS One squat EMG paper.
- PLoS One (Aug 11, 2026): barbell back squat EMG and kinematics paper read in full, open access, verbatim results and

conclusion captured.

- BJSM / JOSPT / Sports Health: Sports Health Aug 7 item (sidestep cutting biomechanics) reviewed, passed over for the tone steer (biomechanics of injury mechanism, not an action).
- NSCA / SimpliFaster / Athletic Lab coaching chatter: scanned for in-season lifting and speed-plateau angles, no new primary finding worth citing.
- PubMed article pages rate-limited (reCAPTCHA) on two direct fetches; worked around via Frontiers full text and a repeat PubMed pull.
- Europe PMC REST had no record yet for the J Sports Sci DOI (ahead-of-print), so the PubMed abstract is the citation target.